

101
CASES WERE REGISTERED AGAINST AHMED

₹416
CRORE WORTH OF PROPERTY BELONGING TO ATIQ AND FAMILY SEIZED SO FAR

17
THE AGE WHEN HE COMMITTED HIS FIRST MURDER

2005 and was murdered. Ahmed and his younger brother Mohammad Ashraf—who were shot dead on April 15 in Prayagraj by assailants in the presence of heavy police force and media—were the accused in the case that ultimately became Ahmed's nemesis. In his first-ever conviction, Ahmed was sentenced to life imprisonment on March 28 in the 17-year-old case for the abduction of Umesh Pal—the witness in Raju Pal's murder who was killed in a brazen daylight attack in February in Prayagraj. The incident brought Ahmed back into the limelight, with ultimately fatal consequences. An FIR was registered against Ahmed, his wife Shaista Parveen, their two sons, Ashraf, and others.

Handlebar-moustachioed Ahmed's writ ran large in Prayagraj and surrounding areas as he straddled the world of crime and politics. His crimes—from murder, robbery, extortion and land grabbing to kidnapping—flourished with political patronage. He was elected five times to the assembly from Allahabad West and once to the Lok Sabha from Phulpur, a constituency once held by Nehru.

Born in Allahabad in 1962 into poverty, Ahmed dropped out of school and later took to a life of petty crime—stealing coal from trains and selling it. He slowly moved up the crime ladder by threatening contractors to bag government tenders for railway scrap metal, before expanding into the land and property business.

Ahmed and Shaista have five sons. Ali and Umar are jailed in separate cases, while two minor ones are now in a shelter home. His third son, Asad, who was wanted in the Umesh Pal murder case, was gunned down by the UP police in an encounter on April 13.

Ahmed was already a hardened criminal at the tender age of 17, when he committed his first murder. By the time he was 27, he had gathered enough power and pelf to enter politics. Soon, he was at loggerheads with the dreaded gangster Shauq-e-Ilahi a.k.a. 'Chand Baba', when he expressed his willingness to contest the assembly election as an Independent. Baba, who gave him the go-ahead initially, later filed the nomination. This triggered animosity between them. On November 6, 1989, Baba was killed in a gruesome gang war in the city's Chowk area. The very next day, when the poll result was announced, Ahmed won with a thumping majority. This bolstered Ahmed's notoriety.

IN HIS FIRST-EVER CONVICTION, AHMED RECEIVED A LIFE SENTENCE IN MARCH FOR THE ABDUCTION OF UMESH PAL, A WITNESS IN MLA RAJU PAL'S MURDER CASE

Ahmed's free run hit a bump when he was named as an accused along with Ashraf and eight others by the CBI in the sensational 2005 murder of Raju, who had defeated Ashraf in the Allahabad West seat in 2005. Ahmed surrendered in 2008 but was released on bail in 2012 to contest the assembly poll, which he lost to Puja. He again unsuccessfully contested the 2014 Lok Sabha election on a Samajwadi Party ticket. However, after Akhilesh Yadav took over the party, Ahmed was sidelined. In 2017, he was denied a party ticket to contest the polls. In February that year, during Yadav's tenure as chief minister, he was arrested for allegedly assaulting staff members of a Prayagraj college but he continued to run his criminal empire from behind bars.

Ahmed tried his electoral luck again in Phulpur as an Independent in the 2018 Lok Sabha bypoll, but could not win. The same year, Lucknow-based businessman Mohit Jaiswal was allegedly kidnapped and taken to Deoria Jail where Ahmed was lodged. According to Jaiswal, he was forced to sign documents handing over his four companies worth over Rs 40 crore to an associate of Ahmed. In April this year, a CBI court in Lucknow framed charges against Ahmed and his son Umar in the case.

Under the ongoing drive by the Yogi government, property worth over Rs 416 crore belonging to Ahmed and his family members has been attached under the Gangsters Act. The dreaded gangland's bloody empire had begun to bite the dust. On April 15, he and his brother too bit the dust in a hail of bullets fired by three assailants. ■